from such texts, or whether this was plucked out by the Buddhist tradition from Ashoka's words, Strong points out, is not easy to answer. What seems likely though is that Ashoka used an idea well understood by people familiar with the faith of the Buddha. If they had not understood what the commingling of gods and humans implied, he would have taken some pains to explain what he meant, as he did with so much else.

The emperor also communicated the possibility of this morality being open and available to all those who followed his example, from the most humble to those who occupied high rank. In emphasizing the possibility of equal access he was quite evidently following the Buddha himself in positioning a new moral universe fundamentally different from the stratified hierarchy of the Brahmanical order. Within the social and cultural milieu of the first millennium BC, it was social differentiation that was usually emphasized: the four varnas—Brahmans, Kshatriyas, Vaishyas, and Shudras—were posited as possessing different innate characteristics and differential access to a variety of social goods, from occupation to justice. This was a relatively absolutist system of reservations. The reservations were supposedly ordained by a primeval divinity, and therefore inviolable. The individual acting against, or against the grain of, his status was thus supposedly disobeying a sacred ordinance—an ordinance which had of course been created, perfected, and imposed by the powerful upon the lowly, and largely internalized both by the lowly and by society at large. Such 'internalization' within Hindu society, i.e. the willing consent to their own subjugation by the subjugated, has been widely exposed by modern interpretation and analysis as among the world's most effective hegemonies precisely because of its incredibly effective deployment of gods and goddesses within great literary stories that were accorded the status of religious texts. The creation of this social and cultural universe of supposedly sacred acts, examples, and orders from heavenly beings who descend into the world of men—partly in order to reinforce the tenets of the